wasn’t interested in expanding eastwards. But trouble in the Ahom kingdom presented an opportunity which it could not resist.

Moamoria rebels had captured Gaurinath’s capital, making his position extremely precarious. After vacillating for a while, Governor General Lord Cornwallis gave permission for the dispatch of a force consisting of 550 men under the command of Captain Thomas Welsh. Three hundred and sixty of them were sepoys from the Bengal Army, while the rest were mainly medics under Doctor John Peter Wade. Captain Welsh’s sepoys were armed with the Short-land Pattern .75 calibre flintlock muskets and the India Pattern of the same weapon. This weapon, popularly known as Brown Bess, was used in the Napoleonic Wars with great success. This was a high-performance musket, which was easier to load, and it took about a minute for an expert soldier to fire four rounds. Though the rebel troops had greatly outnumbered the sepoys time and again, the Moamorias were poorly armed and poorly led; they were completely overwhelmed by the show of British strength. Most Moamorias fought with whatever weapon they could find: swords, pikes, pickaxes, spears, and even bamboo sticks. The battles were generally over even before they began. The British withdrew (as per the non-intervention policy of the new Governor General Sir John Shore) but they left an overawed Ahom kingdom in their wake.

After the withdrawal of the British forces, the political situation deteriorated rapidly and chaos prevailed all over again. The Dundiya Rebellion that played havoc with lives and property in western Assam followed the Moamoria Rebellion. The Ahom prime minister, Purnananda Buragohain, managed to bring about some semblance of order, but in order to further consolidate his power, he appointed all his relatives to high office. This brought him into direct confrontation with Badan Chandra Borphukan who was the governor of Gauhati. There was an assassination attempt that was traced to Borphukan. He then fled to Bengal where he petitioned Governor General Lord Hastings for help to overthrow Purnananda Buragohain. The British were still not willing to play their hand, so Borphukan turned to the Burmese king, Bodaw U Waing, better known as Bodawpaya.

Even the Ahom’s worst enemies could not have scripted a more undignified end to their six-hundred-year rule. The Burmese were quick to exploit the situation. The first intervention was in 1816, where the Burmese faced the Ahom Army at Ghiladhari on 27 March, resulting in the Ahom